Protocols for the Living

Body, emotion and narrative as design material. A teaching proposal for design programmes.

01 INTENT

We usually treat perception and emotion as noise to be filtered out of a design process. This course takes the opposite position. Our innate organic responses, attention, breath, rhythm, fear, wonder, boredom, are the raw material from which new ways of perceiving can be built.

Students design protocols and rituals: short sequences of actions, written so that anyone can perform them, that change how a group relates to a living environment. The work combines field inquiry, behavioural experiments on ourselves and speculative narratives. The social stake is simple: when a group learns to perceive a place differently, it starts to inhabit it differently.

02 THREE AXES

I

Body

A vehicle into ecosystems

The body as a sensor and a participant. Listening walks, breathing and stillness exercises, vocalisation, scale and posture. Students test on themselves how a body enters a milieu and what it changes in it.

Output: a sensory field notebook

II

Emotion

A generator of immersive experience

Emotions are observed, named and located on site. Where does calm appear, where does unease begin? Students build an emotional cartography of a place and learn to design situations that open a specific state rather than illustrate it.

Output: an emotional map of a site

III

Narrative

A structure that creates realities

Stories organise what we are able to see. Through speculative fiction, scores and ritual forms, students write the narrative frame of their experience, then turn it into a protocol that others can perform.

Output: a protocol, written and performed

03 AN EXAMPLE: WAS

WAS (We Are Synchronizers), my research at ENSCI Les Ateliers, started from the way birds share the forest soundscape, each species finding its own acoustic niche. It began with complex devices and ended as a minimal booklet inspired by meditation manuals: a practice where humans join the forest chorus with their own voice. This path, from technology to protocol, is the one the course proposes to students.

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04 TWO POSSIBLE FORMATS

Workshop series

A condensed format of a few intensive days. The three axes are covered in sequence, and each group designs and performs one protocol on a partner site at the end.

Year long programme

One term per axis, body, emotion, narrative. Protocols are tested and refined through the year and brought together in a public ritual on a real site, with its inhabitants.

Partner sites are chosen with the programme: an urban farm, a park, a neighbourhood, any place with living inhabitants and a community around it.

05 PEDAGOGICAL STANCE

Experiment first

Students test every exercise on themselves before proposing it to others. Theory comes as short inputs from ecology, sound studies, anthropology and fiction, always linked to a practice in the field.

No moralising

Nature is not treated as a lesson to deliver. The course stays open to ambivalence: discomfort, strangeness and doubt are part of the material.

Designing for others

The final protocols are run by the students with real participants. Designing an experience means standing inside it with the people who live it.

Assessment

Based on the depth of observation, the clarity of the written protocol, its replicability, and the feedback of participants.

06 BACKGROUND

Workshop design

Founder of CET, immersive workshops on body, space and nature with invited artists. Currently designing a culture for inclusion programme in a public library, combining movement, music and writing.

Education and industry

After studying graphic and multimedia design at ENSAD Paris, I graduated from the Mastère Nature Inspired Design at ENSCI Les Ateliers, where WAS was presented at BiomimExpo and Biome+. Over eight years of luxury retail design, and projects in the social and solidarity economy.

I come to teaching from practice. This note is a starting point: scope, duration and sites can be adjusted to the structure of each programme.

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